

CLAIM SHAME

Their lives were changed forever by one terror attack. But now it is the pain of delayed compensation that prolongs the misery of Mumbai's terror victims.

| By Swati Mathur and Nishika Patel |

On the night of November 26, 2008, fate dealt a cruel blow to Sunita Yadav. The 28-year-old not only lost her husband, but was also left to fend for her daughter Sarika, then only three months old. One year on, her sore eyes are still waiting for the promised railway job. Yadav is just one of the many widows who lost the breadwinner of the family. In other cases, heads of families sustained serious injuries, making them unfit for work.

In a terror attack that left 175 persons dead and 249 injured, victims were eligible to receive compensation from five different agencies—the Union Home Ministry, the Prime Minister's Relief Fund (PMRF), Central Railway, State governments and the Railway Claims Tribunal (RCT). Of these, 614 claims are pending. The release of funds, especially from the Home Ministry and the PMRF, have been fraught with delays. Of the 48 dead that were from Mumbai alone, only 17 families have received home ministry compensation of Rs 3 lakh.

The distribution of disability certificates to nearly 80 victims is still pending. Idzes Kundan, Mumbai city collector and magistrate, responsible for disbursing cheques to the affected, says, "Nearly 71 cases have been sent to J.J. Hospital for a disability certificate." While 44 cases are still being assessed by the hospital, 27 certificates have been received at the collector's office. But there's no movement on the disbursal of Rs 3 lakh to these victims. Similarly, of the 403 dead and injured that were eligible for compensation from the PMRF, only 118 cheques have actually been sent. There are many who are still pinning their hopes on an official assistance. Some examples:

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JAGAN VITTHAL BOKADE, 35, Shot at CST

COMPENSATION DELIVERED: Central Railway (Rs 50,000); State Government (Rs 50,000); PMRF (Rs 1 lakh). He also gets Rs 4,779 per month from his former employer.

COMPENSATION UNDELIVERED: His claim of up to Rs 4 lakh from the Railway Claims Tribunal is still pending. His application seeking compensation of Rs 1 lakh from the Home Ministry was rejected because the name of the beneficiary was incorrect. He has now filed a new application.

Jagan Vitthal Bokade, an employee with Monopoly Express Cargo, was waiting to pick up a consignment at Chhatrapati Shivaji Terminus (CST) on the night of 26/11, when the attack took place. Before he could run for cover, he was hit by a bullet in the right hip, tearing

OF THE 48 DEAD THAT WERE FROM MUMBAI, ONLY 17 families received the Home Ministry's compensation of Rs 3 lakh. Distribution of disability certificates to 80 victims is also pending.